

1856–1869

CRINOLINES

The new crinoline frame provided relief from wearing multi-layered petticoats, but its buoyancy meant that long cotton drawers were now essential underlinen. In the 1860s an oval frame shape evolved and box-pleated skirts gave way to gores panels, which provided a smoother fit over the frame. Bodices and skirts were often separate items, allowing alternate styles of bodice, and front-fastening for convenience. With the availability of domestic sewing machines home-dressmaking increased, as did the use of copious trimmings. Large frames were abandoned after 1867, skirts trailed and were gathered up internally with ties, forming a soft bustle. Then crinolettes and bustle pads took over.

CAGED IN



Putting a dress over a crinoline frame required assistance. A linen chemise, corset, and open drawers with petticoat were worn under a watch-spring steel and tape frame. The dress was then lowered over the head. Lower hoops were later covered, to avoid women putting their feet through the open hoops and tripping up.

1865

Skirt falls vertically at bottom of frame

Bonnet with wide ribbon ties and veil

Outdoor outfit Braids and tassels trim this jacket, emphasising the back. It is worn over a crinoline frame now flatter in front, creating a triangular silhouette. Black and purple were fashionable colours but were also worn for mourning and half-mourning respectively.

Bishop sleeve coming in at wrist; detachable lace cuff to undersleeve

Hair swept back under cap and streamers

Matching wrist bracelets with cameos

Lace-edged handkerchief

Pagoda-shaped sleeves

1859

Evening dress This white silk tulle or muslin dress has stripes, trimmings, and loops formed by silk and ribbon. The ensemble is worn over a large circular frame, and by contrast the boned bodice secures a tiny waist. The collar could be removed for dancing.

Cap sleeves

Matching wrist bracelets with cameos

Rosette finials

Red silk This silk dress is trimmed with braid to create a trompe l'oeil effect. The braid outlines a square neckline, highlights cuffs, creates cap sleeves, and suggests a layered skirt. Red was popular for flannel petticoats and dressing gowns too.